

The Worst Punishment

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Submitted to: Michael Jackson
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Dear Baby,

Henry David Thoreau once said, “You cannot dream yourself into a character; you must hammer and forge yourself one.” Sounds painful, Baby, but it’s true.

I know I will never be like the great man who said that with lots of power and money, but I can tell you my story, Baby, so you will know what I have been through and that I always love you. I hope that will help you in your own journey. With a mother like me, you’ll need all the help you can get!

Baby, I know this is a crazy letter because you aren’t even born yet but I think of all the pain that has gone into my character and I don’t want the same for you. I don’t know what I was thinking. I guess I wasn’t. Back when I was small, life was fun. Now, it’s hell. I scream and I am beaten. I cry and I am alone. I live and I try to fight this hollow empty feeling but it’s the only feeling that’s safe; and not much in my world is safe. I’m sorry for bringing you into this world, Baby.

I have loved writing since I first learned, Baby, even before I could read. I found some details of my mom’s life in a set of letters. I remember looking at the letters on the day she died. I could smell her in the letters. People moved around me but I couldn’t hear any sounds. I remember opening the shoe box under her bed, sitting cross-legged on the carpet while activity bustled around me, slowly eyeing the big round loops swirling across the page, my gaze rushing towards the promise of a period at the end; a tiny little dot to signify finality. But what was the final message? I desperately desired to know. Now I can read but I am still searching for answers. I understand things a little better now

and you know what? I forgave my mother, like I hope you can forgive me. For all my faults, I have tried hard to forgive myself.

I am in jail now at the Alouette Correctional Centre for Women (ACCW). A judge sentenced me to 12 months for breaking and entering and possession of a controlled substance. August 7th was when they locked me in here and it will be 365 days of staring at these walls and fences until I am let out.

I guess I should probably start at the beginning. I was born to Aboriginal parents in Clinton, British Columbia in Canada. My mom was Cree and I'm not too sure about my father. I was an accident. My father only stayed at the hospital long enough to hear me cry. After that we never saw him again.

When I was young, we lived with my mom in our trailer home. It was small but we were happy. Every morning I would get up and make breakfast. Even though I was only five years old I loved being mommy's helper. I remember reaching way up to open the cupboards where the coffee was. The warm smell of the beans as the water dripped down was heaven. I treasured those days.

When I was six years old I started school. I never wanted to go to class because I didn't want to leave my mom alone. I was scared sometimes. Mom started having trouble at work with her boss. Mom said he was a mean person, and he always tried to kiss her but she didn't like it. I came home one night and he was there. I don't know what his name was but I could hear him from outside the trailer. I was so scared I ran up the stairs and burst in the door. I saw blood. I saw red. I raged at Mr. Big, clawing and kicking him with all the force of a six-year-old girl. He grabbed my wrists and laughed. He said my

mother was clumsy. My mother said she was clumsy. Then, he rumbled my hair and left. The door crashed shut. The silence he left behind was as loud as a thousand screams.

I looked to my mother's face. She sniffed, wiped away her mascara, put her hands on my shoulders and with a shaking voice told me how important it was for us to be nice to him. I looked into her eyes and wondered, "Where are you, Mommy?"

After my mom got fired, she got sick. She couldn't get a new job because Mr. Big told everyone she stole money. She needed a helper even more so I had to be in charge of myself, like a grown-up girl. That was fun, but I didn't like when mom was sick. She would get mad and yell mean things.

Baby, I hope that when you are born I have the strength and patience to teach you all the things of the world that my mother couldn't teach me.

When my mom had a drink and her medicine she was happy. When she didn't, she said things like she wished things were different; that it was all my dad's fault and he was no good; she sometimes wanted to die. When she had her medicine, she was happy, or almost happy.

I didn't know any better at the time, Baby. I liked being a good helper for mommy when she needed help with her medicine. I helped. Sometimes I tied the snaky rubber elastic around her slim arm. Her eyes were so distant. Sometimes I pulled her black leather belt tighter to help her find a vein – to help her find peace. I helped her hold the spoon steady. Her hands were so shaky. She always pushed the needle herself. She always pushed it herself unless she was really sick. I helped her lay back.

School was fine at first but as we got older, things got worse. The bullies always picked on me because of how I looked. They said my hair was ratty, my clothes were

dirty and my face was stupid. Even when I tried to be friends, it didn't work out. Their parents told them I was "no good" and they weren't allowed to come over. Mommy didn't like me to go for sleepovers in case she needed me. I wasn't allowed to tell people our business.

I want you to know the whole story, Baby so I will tell you, but I want you to know that even if people call you names, you are special to me and special to God. Don't let the cowards hurt you with their name-calling. In jail, I get called a lot of names. Now that I have you, it doesn't bother me though. I just think about us living on a farm or taking you to baseball games and things feel better. I know there are reasons for living again and a chance for me to make all the wrongs I have done right. You are my reason for living. When we got here, the doctor told me your birthday would be in May! It will only be another seven months until you are born. I can't wait to meet you even if we have to stay here until August. As long as we're together Baby, life will be okay.

Well, the lights will be turned out soon so I will say goodnight for now.

September 30, 2007

I am sorry, Baby. I got in a fight here with my Case Management Officer (CMO). She accused me of being back on drugs. I said I wasn't but she didn't believe me. She said someone gave her an eyewitness statement about me taking drugs. I swear I wasn't doing drugs but I can't prove it until the next drug test. I have been thinking about a lot of things and the fight with the CMO reminded me of the day that changed my life.

That day. It made me who I am today. There was nothing unusual about the day; just this day I snapped. During recess, a group of my classmates gathered around me in

the yard behind the school. I was so young and naïve I thought it was just a joke but my laughter encouraged them.

“Why are you laughing at us, Tanya? Don’t you like us? You’re laughing at us!” Just like my CMO accusing me of being on drugs, their shouted accusations got louder and louder until I realized the tightening circle had turned hostile. I was scared and overwhelmed. I didn’t know what to do. They kept closing in on me and yelling my name. It was terrifying.

One of the girls said, “Tanya, why doesn’t your dad love you? He must have really hated you to leave.” A boy said, “You’re so ugly, *Manya*.”

I screamed and suddenly, everything was a blur. I lost my head and everything went red hot. My hands clenched into fists. “FUCK YOU, MOTHERFUCKERS!” I yelled. I tried to run but there was nowhere to go. I flailed my arms and legs out but it was no use. They held me down and took turn spitting on my face, and throwing grass and dirt in my eyes and mouth. Some of the boys even rubbed their ass on my face, so everyone could see how dirty I was and how much I liked it.

I went numb. I couldn’t fight them physically so I went somewhere else in my mind. I pretended I was a feather, floating over the prettiest meadow, watching the grasses dance to the same rhythm as the waves in the cool river. Each flower was vibrantly colourful and I got lost in each one.

I opened my eyes to dusk and my teacher’s face over mine. There was no one else around. I was still lying on the ground, my face still covered in spit, dirt and grass. When I told my teacher what happened, she told me she would talk to the kids who did it to me.

After that, the kids in my class just ignored me as if I was just a ghost, unwanted and unacknowledged.

I have to tell you now how important you are to me, Baby. I only learned about you when I got to jail but I can feel you growing inside me and I know that when you are old enough to understand this letter, you will be ready for the truth. I know when I was a ghost all those times, I thought of my mommy. I knew my mom loved me and I wasn't afraid. Now that I have you, I'm not afraid anymore either.

October 15, 2007

When I got home that night, the door to our trailer was open. I walked up the stairs and saw my mom sleeping. I was so happy to see her I ran over and hugged her. I wrapped my arms around her and curled up beside her to tell her about my day and the mean kids. Even though I was crying, I thought she was so brave. I pulled her arm around me as I fell asleep beside her. She wasn't sleeping.

In the morning she was getting cold. I was just a kid and I got her another blanket, ate some cereal and waited for the bus, 'cause I knew the only thing worse than facing those kids at school would be if mom found out I was skipping. In the morning the kids were still ignoring me. In the afternoon, the principal came in with a social worker. They wanted to ask about the fight with the kids and how my life was at home. My classmates had said I started swearing at them to start a fight. I was really mad, "They're fucking liars!" I yelled. The insults my classmates had idly thrown about had collected in my head and were storming around like a hurricane. My instability was apparent. The school social worker wanted to meet my mom.

Baby, I hope when people want to meet your mother, you can be proud of me. I have not always made the best decisions but I have tried to be a good person. My Case Management Officer (CMO) is in charge of my file here in jail and she says I'm making a lot of progress. My insight into my own actions and behaviour is increasing and, besides my fight with her earlier, my "responses to conflict" have been "more appropriate". I have been working hard to improve myself so we can have a good life together. I will train for a job as a chef and cook all the delicious meals you want. We can be happy together. I know it.

October 31, 2007

I remember Halloween when I was young. I liked dressing up in costume, pretending to be someone else for an entire day. I wanted to be a royal princess, complete with gown, crown and sceptre. It was almost Halloween when I got in the fight; only I wasn't a princess, I was a troll. The social worker drove my home the next day after school to meet my mom. On the way home, she asked about how things were at home. She wanted to know about mommy's sickness and I told her what a good helper I was. She said I was a very brave little girl but I didn't know why. I didn't feel brave.

When we got back to my house I opened the door for the social worker. Mommy was still asleep on the couch so I ran over to wake her. The social worker came over too, gripped my mom's shoulders and started shaking her.

I yelled at her, "Don't touch my mommy!" but it was too late. She was already on the phone with the police, the ambulance and I don't know who else. I was so confused. I kept yelling at her to WAKE UP! She didn't.

After that, I never saw my mom again. I don't think there was a funeral or if there was, I wasn't invited. It doesn't matter though. She is in my heart forever. No one can take that away from me. I can feel you growing inside me right now. The doctors say your heart is beating so fast so I guess I will be in your heart forever too. If I am lucky, I will get to be in your life too.

November 15, 2007

I hate it here in jail. I am clean now and I learned my lesson but I still have so much time left to serve. All I do is think about how much I've messed up. Life is hard and you can't escape that, just like you can't escape jail. The endless nothingness is enough to drive me back to drugs just from boredom. Some of the women here have dope but I know you don't want that crap in your body. Not yet at least. But I do feel trapped. It was the same way I felt at this one foster home when I was 12 years old.

Once my mom died, I had to move around a lot. No one seemed to want me and the only ones that did already had a house full of brats. None of the kids were happy. I wasn't happy either. Some of the kids were nice though. I made friends with a girl named Gaby. She was older than me, maybe 16 or something. I was young so she protected me from the other big kids. Gaby told me she could show me how to be an independent woman. She would smoke cigarettes like a movie star. Every puff she took was a dramatic flourish of action, intensity and then great relief as she exhaled. She showed me how to smoke cigarettes so the boys would think we were sexy, independent women. At recess we would sneak behind the school for a smoke. I was so happy to have a friend and Gaby told me lots of secrets in exchange for being her helper. I remember my heart

racing as I searched through the other students' bags for money so Gaby could buy us candy and cigarettes.

I don't even know where Gaby is now. Maybe she's in jail like me or still on the streets, shooting up beside dumpsters and tripping out in the alleys. It's an ugly life. Why is society so messed up? I hope I don't mess you up.

December 24, 2007

It's Christmas Eve tonight Baby and I have no one to celebrate with except you. Just the two of us is perfect for me. My mom and I used to have a small Christmas celebration in the trailer. She always got me a gift. Just something small like mittens or a toque but I always loved whatever she picked out. I can't wait to get you a Christmas gift. Without family there isn't much to look forward to. I wonder if there is a traditional Aboriginal ceremony that my people practiced during this time. I don't really know a lot about my heritage but we are learning more about it here in jail. I would like to teach you some things about our people that I am learning. Our ancestors were proud people but being in residential school made them lose their traditional knowledge and drink.

Baby, guess what? I just found out from the doctors that you are a ... GIRL!!! I will have to think of a name that is as beautiful as you. Baby, you are my saviour. Until I found out about you, I was lost and purposeless. Now I know that the Creator put me on this earth to take care of you, the most precious of all. Baby, I just thought of your name! You are my saving Grace.

Merry Christmas, Grace.

January 1, 2008

Rumors are floating around the prison. I have heard that the Warden is going to cancel the Mother-Baby program. Some of the other women who already have children are really worried. They don't know if they will be able to keep their babies or if they will be given to other families. No one wants to see the babies go. They are such a light in an otherwise dark world. The Warden that started in September was confirmed to her position and people are really concerned that she thinks the Mother-Baby program isn't safe. Don't worry, Grace. She won't really cancel it. They can find another way to save money if that's the issue. None of the babies have ever been hurt.

Ahh! This can't be happening. It is only four months until our meeting! I don't want another family to raise you. You are my baby and I am your mother! Why are they doing this to me?!

She WON'T cancel it!!!

January 10, 2008

Secret sources tell me the Warden is going to definitely cancel the Mother-Baby program. I can't believe she would do such a thing! What a ridiculous thing to do. I looked it up and this is against a ton of laws. I looked up the *BC Child Family and Community Services Act* [CFCSA] and the *UN Declaration of the Rights of the Child*, the *Universal Declaration of Human Rights*, and the *Canadian Charter*.

The guiding principles of the CFCSA state that a family is the preferred environment for the care and upbringing of children and the responsibility for the protection of children rests primarily with the parent; and the cultural identity of aboriginal children should be preserved. Both the UN Declaration of the Rights of the Child and the Universal Declaration of Human Rights provide that mothers and children

are entitled to special care and assistance. The Declaration of the Rights of the Child further states that a child “shall, wherever possible, grow up in the care and under the responsibility of his parents, and ... a child of tender years shall not, save in exceptional circumstances, be separated from his mother”.

I have already bonded with you but I don’t know if you’ll get a chance to bond with me when you arrive in this world. If I had been sentenced for longer than two years, I could have gone to FVI, where there is a Mother-Baby program. We could have been together that way. All the pregnant mothers should learn to commit serious crimes if you want to keep your baby.

January 20, 2008

I am so sorry that I am such a screw-up. If I wasn’t such an idiot we could be together like normal families. I fucked it all up that day with Gaby. We were out back of the school at lunch, smoking cigarettes like usual but then Gaby said she had a different type of cigarette – a marijuana cigarette. She pulled out a joint, lit it up, took a puff and passed it to me. It was so sharp compared to cigarette smoke. I coughed and Gaby coughed and then we both looked at each other and started laughing hysterically. We were like jackals, coughing and laughing and coughing some more. We sat behind the school in the grass laughing and eating candy until the bell rang.

“Let’s run away,” Gaby said to me. The words sent shivers through my body at the time. I had never skipped a class before and I couldn’t believe she would think of doing it. I said we would get caught but Gaby had a look in her eyes that defied reason. “Come on, Tans. We can’t go back. We’ll get arrested for smoking the joint. The teachers

will know how high you are and you'll go to jail. Besides, I need your help. Please, Tanya. Please!"

We ran through the woods. We ran until we fell down laughing. Eventually we went home. The foster parents yelled and screamed a lot but there was nothing they could really do to us. We were invincible. Later, when we ran away from home, we told ourselves the same thing, to try and believe that nothing could hurt us; but nothing could have been further from the truth. After Gaby and I decided to leave Clinton, nothing could have stopped us. Gaby had been looking for jobs in Vancouver. That was where all the money was. We couldn't afford a bus ticket so we hitchhiked south. I was 16 or so then, Gaby was 19 and old enough to buy booze. We pretty much always had a small bottle of booze with us on the trip. Gaby liked to bring the baby bottles around, cause she said she was a big baby.

Lots of people would pick us up along the road. We said we were sisters going to Vancouver to visit our father. Our mother was a housewife in Clinton who had sent us with money but a man at the train station had robbed us. Mostly people felt bad for us and would give us some money. Others weren't so nice. They wanted something in return. Gaby knew what they were looking for and was not shy about obliging. It didn't take more than a couple weeks to get to Vancouver.

I told her she didn't have to do those things, but she said it was the way of the world. Her older sister was living in Vancouver and had told her about what it takes to survive. Once we got there, we could start making some real money. Gaby would start out waiting tables and get discovered by a movie talent scout. I would wash windows and become a famous writer. Well now my scripted legacy is this diary to you.

What a messed up kid I was. After we got to Vancouver, I didn't know what I should be doing or how to do it. When it came to getting a job, I had no idea. No one wanted to hire me because I had was so young and didn't have any experience, let alone a resume. Gaby supported me for a bit but she could only make so much as a waitress. She got really mad at me and said I wasn't pulling my weight. Our friendship became strained. We went from best sisters to evil step-sisters and soon enough, she started thinking of ways for me to make money. When Gaby was dressing up for work, I was dressing down, trying to look gritty enough so the tourists would feel bad and give me change. I had some luck getting money for food but just as often, people would avoid me and ignore me. The most I ever got was \$35 in a day. It wasn't good enough for Gaby.

Whatever you do in life, my Baby, remember you are loved so much and you do can achieve whatever you set your mind to. Don't get caught up in following others. Stay focused and understand yourself. I want you to go to school, get educated and be the best person you can be. There are some things in life more important than others. If you follow your heart, you will know exactly where to go.

February 1, 2008

Gracie, if the Warden takes you, I don't know what I'll do. When I get out of here I want to take the Warden's kids, if she has any; just so she knows what it feels like to have her baby ripped from her arms. I am not a bad mother!

If I can keep you, Baby, I promise I will quit drinking and never smoke another thing again! I am not an unfit parent. I just never learned the ways to be a good parent. I am a good person though. A nice person.

February 14, 2008

I don't even care if I live now if I can't have you in my life. I am so depressed. Some of the guards say that if I really wanted you, I shouldn't have done drugs and broken the law. I know it's all my fault but what can I do? I can't change the past. I want to write more and tell you everything but I can barely think of words to say. My brain is slow and I don't know what to say. It's all my fault.

March 1, 2008

I am rotting here in this cell. Like a fruit going bad. Just waiting to have my baby taken away. The pain is like torture. I can't live without you, Baby! YOU ARE ALL I HAVE! Nothing will make me whole again... nothing will help except having my own child in my arms. AHH!

March 15, 2008

Dear Grace, you are smarter than you know. I can tell already that you will be a genius. If you can believe it, you talked to me last night. You said to me, "Mommy, don't worry. I will always be your baby." It made me realize that just like my mother's heart beats in my chest, so does my heart beat in yours. So do the hearts of our ancestors. One of the Native Elders has been teaching me how to make a medicine wheel. It's about balancing the physical, mental, emotional and spiritual elements of ourselves, our families, the community and the wider world. My healing journey began when I learned about you, Baby and I realized that I will be out pretty soon after you are born and we can be together then. You probably won't even notice... I hope... but how could you not.. I know I will miss you every second of every day.

I have been talking with my social worker to help find an Aboriginal family to take care of you but she says it might be hard to find one near the prison. You might have

to live with a white family or another colour family so they can be close enough to bring you for visits. I will be able to pump breastmilk for you if they can transport it safely.

Maybe things will work out but I still don't think it's fair. I feel really sad and hurt that they won't even let us keep our own babies. It truly is the worst punishment.

I have been working through my emotions with the staff here. I'm learning parenting skills and other programs like for substance abuse and anger management... I have tried to read some law now that I am in jail. Even though it's boring and dry, there is some interesting stuff.

Section 38 of the BC Corrections Act Regulations require the Warden to establish programs to assist inmates to "improve their education or training, and reduce the risk they present to the community". The UN Declaration on the Rights of the Family and the Rights of Mother & Child clearly say we should be together, Baby, NOT APART! The strategic plan released by BC Corrections also says there are supposed to be programs specifically for Aboriginal female offenders. I guess that's the two of us until your birthday.

I don't want you to remember a time when I wasn't there for you.

April 14, 2008

To Grace, my dear daughter,

It's official now. The Warden cancelled the Mother-Baby program at ACCW. Unless I find some way out of here, we will be apart for the first few months of your life. Your birthday is only a month away! There could not be a more difficult thing for a mother to do. I thought taking someone's first born child was something you did in

exchange for the power to spin gold from hay; not as punishment in addition to jail. They don't really need to do this but they think women like us shouldn't have kids.

I have been in touch with some lawyers and they are on our side. They want to launch a constitutional challenge to the cancellation of the Program under the Canadian Charter of Rights and Freedoms. I only hope it's as powerful as it sounds. I guess we'll see, won't we Gracie.

Guess what? My social worker helped arrange to have an Aboriginal family near the prison look after you while I finish out the end of my sentence. They want to teach you all about your heritage and keep you healthy; plus, they are close enough to bring you for visits with me. I will give them some breast milk in bottles for you, Grace.

I am so sorry about some of the choices I have made. I guess I wasn't aware of how my actions impacted the world – myself included. Regardless, I am the woman I am today because of those choices. I have a lifetime of laughter and a lifetime of heartache under my belt already and I'm not even 25. I will miss seeing your first few months as you discover everything for the first time. Mostly I am sorry I can't be there for you during your first experience of the world. I would love to see how your little fingers grab at everything new, your wrinkly arms flailing about in search of me, your loving mommy. Your birth will be my re-birth.

There will be so many challenges ahead. Other women say they have been shackled to the bed during delivery. I will have to live with the pain of living in here without you, but I am paying my debt to society for being young and poor. The lawyers say the legal challenge will be a stressful time because I will have to answer lots of personal questions but I am doing it all for you, Grace. I love you!